TEACHER COPY · VERSION B · the key is in bold, with why under each answer

READING CHECK: "BISCUIT" AND "THE REEDS OF THE NORTH LAGOON"

Version B

Grade 7 · English / Reading · Making inferences and citing text evidence (fiction and nonfiction)

Read the story and the article. Then answer each question. Fill in the circle next to the best answer.

Biscuit

Fiction · Written for this quiz.

1 Mrs. Abara handed Kiran her spare key and a page of notes. "Biscuit is shy with new people, so don't take it personally," she said. At the bottom she had written: Dev will come Thursday to water the plants. Kiran had asked his parents for a pet for three years. Four days with Biscuit felt like a test, and he planned to get a perfect score.

2 On Monday morning the apartment was silent. Kiran filled the bowl and crouched by the couch. "Here, kitty, kitty!" He shook the food bag and tapped the bowl with a spoon, louder each time. He walked to school with his shoulders up near his ears.

3 That evening the bowl was empty, and the blanket on the armchair was warm and covered in orange hair. Kiran looked behind the mat. Nothing had spilled. At dinner his sister Tam said, "So she ate!" Kiran shook his head. "Dev must have come by and tossed it out. She won't touch anything I give her."

4 On Tuesday he tried harder. He waved a feather toy under the bed and sang to her. Two green eyes watched him from the dark, then slid away. "She misses Mrs. Abara too much to eat," he told Tam. "And she hates me." Tam shrugged. "Or you're loud."

5 On Wednesday evening Kiran had a math test to study for and no energy for singing. He sat on the floor against the couch, opened his notebook, and forgot to call her at all.

6 After a while, something warm leaned against his elbow. Biscuit sat beside him, staring at the page as if she were checking his work. Kiran did not reach for her. He kept writing, but slower. She stayed until he finished the last problem.

7 On Thursday, Dev was watering the plants when Mrs. Abara got home. She glanced at Kiran's notebook. "I used to teach math, you know." Kiran started to say, "She didn't eat at first," then looked at Dev and stopped. Biscuit was curled on the armchair, watching him. "Could I come over sometimes?" he asked. "I'd bring my homework."

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Questions 1-5: "Biscuit"

1. In paragraph 4, what does Tam think the problem is? L1 · infer a character's feelings or beliefs

A. Biscuit misses her owner too much.

B. Kiran is making too much noise.

C. Biscuit is shy with people she doesn't know.

D. The feather toy frightens Biscuit.

Answer: **B. Kiran is making too much noise.**
Why: Tam answers Kiran's ideas with "Or you're loud" [4]. Missing Mrs. Abara is Kiran's idea [4], not Tam's; "shy with new people" is Mrs. Abara's warning [1]; the feather toy is only what Kiran waves [4].

2. In paragraph 3, why does Kiran shake his head at dinner? L2 · infer why a character acts

A. He thinks Biscuit spilled most of it behind the mat.

B. He wants Tam to stop asking about Biscuit.

C. He believes someone else emptied Biscuit's bowl.

D. He thinks Biscuit ate only a few bites of it.

Answer: **C. He believes someone else emptied Biscuit's bowl.**
Why: Tam says "So she ate!" and Kiran shakes his head: "Dev must have come by and tossed it out" [3]. He checked behind the mat and "Nothing had spilled" [3]; Tam is not nagging, she says one line; he does not think Biscuit ate any of it ("She won't touch anything I give her" [3]).

3. Part A: In paragraph 7, why does Kiran offer to bring his homework when he visits? L3 · infer what a character realizes

A. He hopes Biscuit will come sit by him again while he works.

B. He hopes Biscuit will let him pet her while he studies.

C. He thinks Biscuit likes being sung to while he works.

D. He thinks Biscuit is lonely without Mrs. Abara.

Answer: **A. He hopes Biscuit will come sit by him again while he works.**
Why: Two steps: on Wednesday Biscuit sat beside him while he did math and "stayed until he finished the last problem" [6]; on Thursday he looks at Biscuit watching him and then offers to bring homework [7], so he connects her coming near with him sitting and working. He "did not reach for her" [6], so petting is not what drew her; he had "no energy for singing" on Wednesday [5], and singing made her slide away [4]; missing Mrs. Abara was his wrong Tuesday idea [4].

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4. Part B: Which line from the story BEST supports your Part A answer?

L2 · choose the best supporting quotation

A. "When he reached out, she rubbed her head on his hand." [6]

B. "He sang softly to her as he did his math." [5]

C. "She misses Mrs. Abara too much to eat," [4]

D. "She stayed until he finished the last problem." [6]

Answer: **D. "She stayed until he finished the last problem." [6]**

Why: Key: Biscuit stayed beside him until his homework was done [6], so she comes near when he sits and works. "She misses Mrs. Abara too much to eat" [4] is real and backs "lonely without Mrs. Abara." "When he reached out, she rubbed her head on his hand" is unmatched (backs "let him pet her"): the passage contradicts it; the real line in [6] is "Kiran did not reach for her." "He sang softly to her as he did his math" is unmatched (backs "likes being sung to"): the real line in [5] says he had "no energy for singing" and "forgot to call her at all."

5. On Monday morning, what does Kiran do to get Biscuit to come out? Quote one sentence that shows it and give its paragraph number. L2 · cite evidence for a claim

Answer: **He calls her and makes more and more noise with the food: "He shook the food bag and tapped the bowl with a spoon, louder each time." [2]**

Why: Full credit: calling or the bag and bowl noise, plus a [2] sentence. "He calls her" with no line or detail from [2] earns at most half credit.

The Reeds of the North Lagoon

Nonfiction · Written for this quiz. Vessa Island, its people and its animals are invented.

1 Vessa Island has two shallow lagoons, North and South, with a strip of sand between them. Tall tolla reeds once grew thick along both shores. A long-legged gray bird called the drell nests only in thick reeds. At night it wades through the mud and eats kib snails.

2 In the winter of 1961, a storm flattened the reeds around the North Lagoon. The South Lagoon, behind higher dunes, lost only a few. With nowhere to nest, the North Lagoon's drells flew off. Some fishermen were glad. They believed drells ate young fish, though no one had ever seen one do it.

3 Everyone expected the reeds to come back in a year or two, as they had after smaller storms. They did not. Each spring, green shoots poked up from the mud, and each summer they were gone. Islanders blamed the salt the storm had washed in.

4 In 1968, a teacher named Hana Selk tested the North Lagoon's water and found it no saltier than the South's. Then she went out after dark with a lamp. The mud was crowded with kib snails, and they were eating the new shoots down to the roots. Without drells, almost nothing was eating the kibs.

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5 The islanders first tried planting reeds by hand. The snails ate those too. So in 1971 Selk's students built wooden nesting platforms and hid them in the last reed clumps. Two pairs of drells moved in the next spring.

6 The change was slow. For five summers the shoots kept vanishing, and some islanders said the platforms were a waste of wood. By 1980, though, every platform was in use, the snails were thinner on the mud, and reeds stood again along the North Lagoon's shore.

7 The fishermen's catch did not drop when the drells came back. If anything, it rose. Young fish hide among reed stems.

8 Selk later wrote, "The storm knocked the reeds down. The missing birds kept them down."

Questions 6-12: "The Reeds of the North Lagoon"

6. According to the article, who built the nesting platforms? L1 · find a detail in the text

A. the fishermen of the North Lagoon

B. islanders from the South Lagoon

C. Hana Selk's students

D. Hana Selk and the fishermen

Answer: **C. Hana Selk's students**

Why: "Selk's students built wooden nesting platforms" [5]. The fishermen are only mentioned as glad the drells left [2] and in the catch [7]; Selk is never said to have built them herself; South Lagoon islanders are not mentioned.

7. Why did the South Lagoon most likely lose only a few reeds in the 1961 storm? L2 · infer a cause the text does not spell out

A. Its higher dunes kept the worst of the storm away.

B. Its drells kept the hungry snails off the young shoots.

C. Its water was much less salty than the North Lagoon's.

D. Its reeds grew farther from the open sea.

Answer: **A. Its higher dunes kept the worst of the storm away.**

Why: The South Lagoon is "behind higher dunes" and "lost only a few" [2]: the dunes sheltered it from the storm. The snails ate shoots after the storm, not during it [3]-[4]; Selk found the North no saltier than the South [4]; the article never says where the open sea is.

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8. The first drells moved onto the platforms in 1972, but the new shoots kept vanishing for years afterward. Based on the article, what most likely explains the delay?

L3 · trace a cause-and-effect chain

A. Salt from the 1961 storm was still in the water.

B. Two pairs of drells were too few for all the kibs.

C. The new drells ate young fish, not kib snails.

D. The reed roots needed years to heal from the kibs.

Answer: **B. Two pairs of drells were too few for all the kibs.**

Why: Two steps: only two pairs moved in at first [5]; by 1980 every platform was in use and the snails were thinner on the mud [6]; so it took more drells to thin out the kibs. Selk found the water no saltier than the South's [4]; drells eat kib snails [1] and no one had seen one eat fish [2]; shoots came up every spring [3], so the roots were alive, and the shoots vanished because kibs ate them [4].

9. Part A: What does the article suggest about the belief that drells ate young fish?

L3 · infer why the author includes a detail

A. It was proved true by fishermen in 1960.

B. It was true, though the harm to the fish was small.

C. It led the fishermen to drive the drells away.

D. It was only a guess, with nothing to back it up.

Answer: **D. It was only a guess, with nothing to back it up.**

Why: Two steps: "no one had ever seen" a drell eat young fish [2], and when the drells came back the catch did not drop and if anything rose [7]. So nothing backed the belief. Nothing shows it was proved (no one saw it [2]); nothing shows any harm to fish (the catch rose [7]); the drells flew off because they had nowhere to nest [2], not because fishermen drove them away.

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10. Part B: Which line from the article BEST supports your Part A answer?

L2 · choose the best supporting quotation

A. "They believed drells ate young fish, though no one had ever seen one do it." [2]

B. "In 1960, fishermen counted dozens of drells eating young fish." [1]

C. "The fishermen's catch did not drop when the drells came back." [7]

D. "The fishermen chased the last drells off with nets." [2]

Answer: **A. "They believed drells ate young fish, though no one had ever seen one do it." [2]**
Why: Key: the belief had no sighting behind it [2]. "The fishermen's catch did not drop" [7] is real and backs "true, though the harm to the fish was small." "In 1960, fishermen counted dozens of drells eating young fish" is unmatched (backs "proved true"): the passage contradicts it; the real line in [1] is "At night it wades through the mud and eats kib snails," and [2] says no one had ever seen a drell eat a young fish. "The fishermen chased the last drells off with nets" is unmatched (backs "drive the drells away"): the real line in [2] is "With nowhere to nest, the North Lagoon's drells flew off."

11. Why does the article say the platforms were hidden in the last reed clumps?

L2 · infer why the author includes a detail

A. because a storm like the one in 1961 might flatten them

B. because snails could not climb into thick reeds

C. because drells will nest only where reeds grow thick

D. because hunting birds might spot them

Answer: **C. because drells will nest only where reeds grow thick**
Why: The drell "nests only in thick reeds" [1], and the last reed clumps [5] were the only reeds left standing to hide the platforms in. Nothing says the clumps sheltered the platforms from storms or that snails cannot climb reeds (they ate the shoots [4]); hunting birds are never mentioned.

12. What does "in use" mean as it is used in paragraph 6? Give one detail from another paragraph that shows it happening, and give the paragraph number. L2 · word meaning from context, with evidence

Answer: **Being used for nests; drells were nesting on the platforms: "Two pairs of drells moved in the next spring." [5]**
Why: Full credit: a meaning like "had drells nesting on them" plus the [5] detail of the two pairs moving in. "Used by people" or "being fixed" does not fit. A meaning with no detail from the passage earns at most half credit.

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CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE (4 points)

Write your answer on the lines.

13. How does the way Kiran treats Biscuit change from Monday to Wednesday evening? Use RACE: R - Restate the question. A - Answer it. C - Cite two pieces of evidence with [paragraph numbers]. E - Explain how each piece of evidence proves your answer. L3 · infer how a character changes (RACE)

> A strong answer: **Kiran goes from chasing Biscuit with noise to leaving her alone and letting her come to him. He taps the bowl "louder each time" [2] and sings to her [4]; on Wednesday he "did not reach for her" and kept writing [6].**
>
> Why: Score with the RACE CHECKLIST. Strong evidence: [2] or [4] for Monday and Tuesday; [5] or [6] for Wednesday evening ([7] is Thursday, outside the question). The Explain row needs how each quote shows the change.

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Skills and level map

Each question's skill and level (1 = on-ramp, 2 = on level, 3 = harder, often two steps). Version A and B test the same skill at the same level, question for question.

Level 1: 2 (15%)	**Level 2**: 7 (54%)	**Level 3**: 4 (31%)

Skill	Questions	How many
infer a character's feelings or beliefs	1	1
infer why a character acts	2	1
infer what a character realizes	3	1
choose the best supporting quotation	4, 10	2
cite evidence for a claim	5	1
find a detail in the text	6	1
infer a cause the text does not spell out	7	1
trace a cause-and-effect chain	8	1
infer why the author includes a detail	9, 11	2
word meaning from context, with evidence	12	1
infer how a character changes (RACE)	13	1

#	Skill	Level	Type	Key (version B)
1	infer a character's feelings or beliefs	1	mc	**B. Kiran is making too much noise.**
2	infer why a character acts	2	mc	**C. He believes someone else emptied Biscuit's bowl.**
3	infer what a character realizes	3	mc	**A. He hopes Biscuit will come sit by him again while he works.**
4	choose the best supporting quotation	2	mc	**D. "She stayed until he finished the last problem." [6]**
5	cite evidence for a claim	2	short	**He calls her and makes more and more noise with the food: "He shook the food bag and tapped the bowl with a spoon, louder each time." [2]**
6	find a detail in the text	1	mc	**C. Hana Selk's students**

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7	infer a cause the text does not spell out	2	mc	**A. Its higher dunes kept the worst of the storm away.**
8	trace a cause-and-effect chain	3	mc	**B. Two pairs of drells were too few for all the kibs.**
9	infer why the author includes a detail	3	mc	**D. It was only a guess, with nothing to back it up.**
10	choose the best supporting quotation	2	mc	**A. "They believed drells ate young fish, though no one had ever seen one do it." [2]**
11	infer why the author includes a detail	2	mc	**C. because drells will nest only where reeds grow thick**
12	word meaning from context, with evidence	2	short	**Being used for nests; drells were nesting on the platforms: "Two pairs of drells moved in the next spring." [5]**
13	infer how a character changes (RACE)	3	open	**Kiran goes from chasing Biscuit with noise to leaving her alone and letting her come to him. He taps the bowl "louder each time" [2] and sings to her [4]; on Wednesday he "did not reach for her" and kept writing [6].**

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